

sure 25 of those listeners would be just me. I saw a YouTube video where if you put a blanket over your head then the voice doesn't mumble, so I was under a blanket trying to record like this. One time a guest said yes and I couldn't arrange a freelancer at a cheap price, so I was the only one who was a recorder. I put out a camera and we did the whole episode. Later we realised I only recorded him and not me, because I forgot to click the record button. So that episode is still only one-sided.

Was there one episode or guest that changed your trajectory?

Raj: When I look back, we don't even have one episode which has worked out well for us. Every new kind of episode has gotten us a new audience. Would you call Vijay Mallya an episode which blew up? Probably yes, but that got us a South India audience. Would you call President Macron's episode really big? Yes, but that got us a European audience. So I don't have one moment. It has always been incremental growth – we have never had an exponential moment till now.

Data can be brutal to a podcaster's confidence. What's your philosophy?

Raj: Don't marry an ideology. That's one of the biggest problems that a lot of people have – I have this ideology and I'm only going to do this. And that's wrong, because every six months the world will tell you something else. The most important thing, where most people fail, is they compromise their value system. We have it written in very bold letters in our office: we don't chase trends, we chase teachings. We don't chase views, we chase values. We don't chase sensationalism, we chase sense. The data tells you in India the top five categories which work on content is horror, astrology, sex, erotic conversations, religion and entertainment. Tell me one other podcast apart from us

Don't take yourself seriously, and don't think anything will happen for at least the first three years and the first 100 episodes. If you are thinking for magic to happen before that, then you are in the wrong game. I see this game as a 10-year game minimum. We don't even think about returns or making money or making it really big until the 10-year mark.

who's in the top 10 and doesn't follow at least one of them. We are the only one. We don't make content on any of the five topics which are the highest consumed topics in the country, because our value system doesn't allow us to do that. So the idea is, do you have a strong value system? If yes, use data to just amplify whatever is in your zone.

Audiences assume podcasting is a mic and a chat. What happens behind scenes that they don't see?

Raj: If someone's investing two hours to watch a podcast with us, they need to learn something new which they've never learned. So our entire podcast is designed from start to end to make it like a movie. And we never start with the guest. In our team there's a process called T-sheet. Every week people make a topic list of what we should teach the world, then they select two or three topics and make a thumbnail out of it, they draw it by hand. Then people vote and the top three get decided. Those top three go to the guest team, which starts finding the top people in the world who can teach something about this. Then

we send them a pre-brief, which is very simple: we want to derive lessons out of you. Then my team of strategists and researchers interview the guest – yes he is great, but can he teach? Then my team of researchers for seven days will prepare a 30 to 40 page research document, strategists will make a content document of all the questions, and I will read all of that one night before. The guest doesn't know our questions. When the podcast is done then it goes to a content strategist, who will cut the parts which are boring and arrange the whole podcast in a way which is as engaging as a movie. Then it goes to a QC team, who check whether everything the guest has said is factually correct and only after that the podcast is published. And then for the next 48 hours there's a data guy who's seeing the CTR, the subscriber-to-view ratio, the average view duration – where is it dropping, how can we get it better for the next time. At times, when the podcast is time sensitive, we have also pulled off the entire podcast in a day and we follow the exact same process even for those podcasts. 90% of the episodes we do are not exactly time sensitive, we make podcasts that will be evergreen and stay relevant for really long time.

How hard is it to secure a guest, and what has that taught you about persistence?

Raj: Getting the guest never gets easy for you. Never. Anyone who's living under the impression that one day getting guests will become easy is living under a rock. You're always chasing left, right, centre, and you're always getting rejected. So for us, if we are not getting rejected in a week by at least 100 people, we don't think we're trying enough. When I started I used to reach out to 100 people a day, one or two used to reply. Till today my team reaches out to 100 people a day, or probably a week, and only one or two reply. As you grow, the aspiration of the guest also grows.